

Clause order

Subordinate clauses that start with relative pronouns always follow the noun or pronoun they are describing. If a subordinate clause starts with a subordinator or a participle, however, it can occupy different positions in a sentence.

▷ Ending a sentence

When a subordinate clause is placed at the end of a sentence, no comma is required to separate the clauses unless the sentence is long and would otherwise be confusing.

▷ Starting a sentence

If the subordinate clause is placed at the start of a sentence, however, it must be separated from the main clause that follows by a comma.

▷ Sitting in the middle

Similarly, if a subordinate clause breaks up a main clause, a comma is required at the start and end of the clause to separate it from the main clause.

The subordinate clause is separated from the main clause by a subordinator, so no comma is required.

Rob hid in a corner because he hated dancing.

This subordinate clause is at the beginning of the sentence, so a comma is required to separate the two clauses.

Until the class was over, Rob hid in a corner.

This subordinate clause has split the main clause into two parts, so commas are required to show which parts belong to which clauses.

Rob, feeling bored, hid in a corner.

Multiple subordinate clauses

As long as a complex sentence contains at least one main clause, more than one subordinate clause can be used. The easiest way to construct a complex sentence is to start with a main clause and then add the subordinate clauses, one at a time.

GLOSSARY

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Relative pronoun A pronoun that links one part of a sentence to another by introducing a relative clause, which describes an earlier noun or pronoun.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

Subordinate clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb but depends on a main clause for its meaning.

Subordinator A conjunction used to connect words, phrases, and clauses of unequal importance.

A subordinate clause has been added to make this a complex sentence.

Tim missed the class.

main clause

Although he loved dancing, Tim missed the class.

main clause

subordinate clause

Although he loved dancing, Tim missed the class, which was full.

main clause

A second subordinate clause has been added.